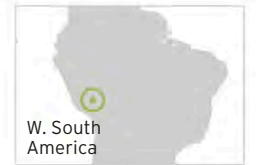


Sacsayhuamán

The largest fortress-temple complex built by the Incas, remarkable for its precisely constructed dry-stone walls



The citadel of Sacsayhuamán occupies an imposing position on a hill to the north of the city of Cuzco, Peru, the capital of the Inca Empire. It was originally established by the Killke people in about 1100, but when the Incas took over the region in the 13th century, they expanded and fortified the complex.

Regarded as both a fortress and a complex of temples, the three terraced levels of Sacsayhuamán are protected by stone walls up to 59 ft (18 m) high. These defensive walls at the foot of the citadel are laid out in an unusual zigzag pattern, designed so that attackers could be fired upon from several directions.

Perfect fit

The Incas originally reinforced the citadel with simple clay and mud walls, but in the mid-15th century, they began to replace these with the massive dry-stone walls for which Sacsayhuamán has become famous. Enormous blocks of stone, weighing as much as 110 tons (100 tonnes), were quarried, then pounded and carved into polygonal shapes with such precision that they fit perfectly together without the need for mortar.

According to Inca legend, the city of Cuzco was known as the “lion city” and was laid out in the form of a puma when viewed from above; the citadel at Sacsayhuamán was intended to be its head.

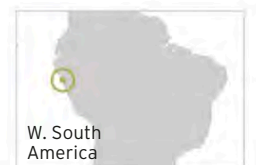
▽ INCA CITADEL

This image shows the central area of the complex, built on terraces on the promontory above Cuzco.



Chan Chan

The capital of the Chimú empire, with a central complex of 10 compounds separated by thick mud-brick walls



△ VAST ADOBE CITY

The earthen-walled city of Chan Chan covered about 8 square miles (20 square km). The compounds were well planned and enclosed by diamond-shaped sand walls.

Chan Chan (also known as Chimor) was a thriving city in the Chimú civilization of northern Peru between the 12th and 15th centuries. Situated on the coast at the mouth of the Rio Moche, it evolved from a primarily agricultural settlement through the building of canals and reservoirs that served a sprawling city arranged in distinct units. The grandest of these units are the 10 rectangular *ciudadelas* containing palace and administrative buildings made from adobe bricks of cast mud and enclosed by 33-ft- (10-m-) high walls. The walls are decorated on the outside with high-relief geometric patterns and depictions of animals and fish.

While the nature of the premolded, earthen blocks used in the city's construction renders them liable to deterioration, the dry climate has kept them essentially intact to date. Moreover, under the protection of World Heritage Site status, an ongoing program of sympathetic maintenance has preserved much of the site for posterity.